



Cultural Differences

Understanding Chinese culture, customs, and social norms for
foreigners

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Article 1

Why China Loves When Foreigners Wear Hanfu and Ethnic Clothing

If you've ever walked through a Chinese city wearing a hanfu (汉服, traditional Chinese clothing) or other ethnic minority garments, you've probably experienced something unexpected: huge smiles, requests for photos, and people telling you "好看!" (hǎokàn -- beautiful!). This reaction isn't random -- it reflects deep cultural values about hospitality, cultural pride, and the Chinese concept of "天下" (tiānxià -- "all under heaven").

The Cultural Context: Why Chinese People Are Thrilled

In Chinese culture, when a foreigner voluntarily embraces Chinese traditions -- wearing hanfu, learning Chinese calligraphy, eating with chopsticks, or celebrating Spring Festival -- it's seen as the highest form of cultural respect. The Chinese concept of



"有朋自远方来，不亦乐乎" (yǒu péng zì yuǎnfāng lái, bù yì lè hū -- "Is it not a joy to have friends come from afar?", from Confucius) is deeply ingrained in the national psyche.

Unlike some cultures where wearing traditional clothing of another culture might be viewed as appropriation, Chinese culture generally views it as appreciation. The key difference is the concept of "文化自信" (wénhuà zìxìn -- "cultural confidence") -- China's growing pride in its 5,000-year heritage. When foreigners participate, it validates that pride.

Hanfu: A Living Tradition

Hanfu (汉服) has experienced a massive revival in China, especially among Gen Z. The hanfu market exceeded ¥10 billion in 2023. Major cities have hanfu rental shops near tourist areas where you can rent a complete outfit for ¥50-200 for a day. Popular locations include:



* Xi'an

* -- The hanfu capital. Near the Terracotta Army and Muslim Quarter, dozens of rental shops offer Tang Dynasty-style outfits. Walking in the Ancient City Wall area in hanfu is a quintessential experience.

* Beijing

* -- Near the Forbidden City and Nanluoguxiang. Many visitors rent Ming Dynasty-style hanfu for photos against the palace backdrop.

* Hangzhou

* -- West Lake area. Song Dynasty-style hanfu in the gardens is incredibly photogenic.

* Luohe / Kaifeng

* -- Song Dynasty theme parks where hanfu rental is included with entry.

Ethnic Minority Clothing



China has 55 officially recognized ethnic minorities, each with distinctive clothing.

Popular among tourists:

- * Miao (苗族)

- * -- Elaborate silver headdresses and embroidered garments. Common in Guizhou and Yunnan.

- * Tibetan (藏族)

- * -- Chuba robes with colorful sashes. Popular in Lhasa and western China.

- * Dai (傣族)

- * -- Flowing, Southeast Asian-style garments. Common in Yunnan's Xishuangbanna.

- * Korean-Chinese (朝鲜族)

- * -- Chima jeogi dresses. Popular in Yanbian, Jilin province.

What to Expect When Wearing Traditional Clothing

- * Photo requests



* -- Strangers will ask to take photos with you. This is normal and friendly, not creepy.

* Compliments

* -- People will say "好看!" (beautiful), "漂亮!" (pretty), or "你好厉害!" (you're amazing).

* Discounts

* -- Some tourist attractions offer free entry or discounts if you're wearing hanfu.

* Social media moments

* -- Don't be surprised if someone films a short video with you for Douyin (TikTok).

Tips for Wearing Hanfu Respectfully

* Don't wear it as a joke or costume -- treat it with respect

* Learn the basic wearing method (the lapel wraps left over right for living people, right over left for the deceased)

* If unsure, ask the rental shop to help you dress



* Avoid mixing incompatible dynasty styles

Sources: Sources: https://www.thepaper.cn/newsDetail_forward_25376489 -- 澎湃新闻

汉服产业报告

 • <http://www.gov.cn> -- 中国政府网 -- 民族文化

"老外" Is Not Rude: Understanding Chinese

Nicknames and Terms for Foreigners

One of the first things foreigners in China notice is being called "老外" (lǎowài). Some newcomers feel offended, thinking it means "old foreigner" or is somehow disrespectful.

In reality, it's one of the most common and generally neutral-to-friendly terms Chinese people use for foreigners. To understand why, you need to understand how the Chinese prefix "老" (lǎo -- "old") works in names.

The "老 + Surname" Convention: A Sign of Familiarity

In Chinese, adding "老" (lǎo) before someone's surname is a common, affectionate way to address friends, colleagues, and acquaintances. It signals familiarity and warmth --

NOT that the person is old:



* 老王 (Lǎo Wáng) -- "Old Wang" = a friendly way to refer to someone named Wang

* 老李 (Lǎo Lǐ) -- "Old Li" = same, for someone named Li

* 老张 (Lǎo Zhāng) -- "Old Zhang" = same, for someone named Zhang

* 老刘 (Lǎo Liú) -- "Old Liu" = same, for someone named Liu

This is used for people of ALL ages -- a 25-year-old named Wang can be called 老王 by friends and colleagues. It's equivalent to saying "mate" in British English or "dude" in American English. Nobody is commenting on age.

So What Does "老外" Actually Mean?

"老外" follows the same pattern -- "老" (lǎo) + "外" (wài, short for 外国人 wàiguó rén, "foreigner"). It literally means something like "the foreigner" in a casual, familiar way.

It's the same linguistic pattern as 老王, 老李, etc.

The term became popular in the 1980s-90s as China opened up and more foreigners



visited. It's roughly equivalent to:

- * "Expat" in English (neutral descriptor)

- * "Gaijin" (外人) in Japanese (though gaijin can carry more nuance)

- * "Gringo" in Latin American Spanish (can be neutral or slightly teasing, depending on context)

Tone Matters: When Is It Friendly vs. Slightly Rude?

- *

- * Friendly/Neutral:

- * "那个老外中文说得真好！" (That foreigner's Chinese is really good!) -- This is a compliment.

- *

- * Friendly/Neutral:

- * "你是老外吧？" (You're a foreigner, right?) -- Just a casual observation.



* !

* Possibly dismissive:

* "老外不懂的" (Foreigners don't understand this) -- Can be slightly condescending, but usually not hostile.

*

* Rarely rude:

* Shouted at someone aggressively -- but this is extremely uncommon.

Other Terms for Foreigners You Might Hear

* 外国人 (wàiguórén) -- "Foreign person." Formal, neutral, used in official contexts.

* 外籍人士 (wàijí rénshì) -- "Foreign national." Very formal, used in legal/official documents.

* 洋人 (yáng rén) -- "Ocean person." Older term from the colonial era. Rarely used today, can sound old-fashioned.



* 歪果仁 (wāiguǒrén) -- Internet slang/meme pronunciation of 外国人. Playful, not offensive.

* 国际友人 (guójì yǒurén) -- "International friend." Used in formal/political contexts. Very polite.

The Flip Side: Chinese Nicknames for Each Other

Chinese people use nickname prefixes for everyone, not just foreigners:

* 小 + surname (xiǎo -- "little"): 小王, 小李 -- for younger people or juniors

* 老 + surname (lǎo -- "old"): 老王, 老李 -- for peers or slightly older people

* 大 + surname (dà -- "big"): 大刘, 大张 -- for someone who's tall or older

* 阿 + surname (ā): 阿明, 阿花 -- common in southern China, very affectionate

Bottom Line



If someone calls you "老外," smile -- they're treating you like a familiar presence in their community, not insulting you. If it bothers you, you can gently say "叫我[你的名字]就好" (jiào wǒ [name] jiù hǎo -- "Just call me [name]") and most people will happily switch.

Sources: Sources: 百度百科 --

老外 • 教育部语言文字应用研究所



Article 3

Shopping Culture Shock: Bargaining, Staff Following You, and Why They Seem "Pushy"

If you've just arrived in China and went shopping, you might have experienced some things that felt uncomfortable or confusing: a shop assistant following you around the store, a market vendor physically trying to pull you into their stall, or being expected to haggle over prices. These behaviors are deeply rooted in Chinese shopping culture and understanding them will transform your shopping experience from stressful to fun.

Why Staff Follow You Around the Store

In Western retail, having an employee follow you often signals suspicion (are you shoplifting?). In China, it's the opposite -- it's a form of customer service called "跟客" (gēn kè, "following the customer"). Here's why:



* Proactive service

* -- Staff are trained to be immediately available when you need help. In Chinese retail culture, waiting for a customer to ask is considered lazy service.

* Commission-based pay

* -- Many store employees earn commission (提成 tíchéng). Their income depends on making sales, so they want to be near you to answer questions and close deals.

* Cultural expectation

* -- Chinese customers often expect attentive service. A store where nobody approaches you might be seen as having poor service.

* Loss prevention

* -- Yes, some of it is also anti-theft, especially in cosmetics, electronics, and luxury stores. This is more practical than accusatory.

How to Handle It:



* "我随便看看" (wǒ suíbiàn kànkàn -- "I'm just browsing") -- This is the magic phrase.

Staff will usually give you some space.

* "不用了，谢谢" (bú yòng le, xièxiè -- "No need, thanks") -- Polite but firm.

* A simple smile and nod acknowledges their presence without engaging further.

* Don't take it personally -- they do this to every customer, not just foreigners.

The Art of Bargaining (砍价 kǎnjià)

Bargaining is expected (and fun!) at many types of shops in China, but NOT everywhere:

Always bargain:

* Markets (市场 shìchǎng) -- Silk Market (Beijing), Yuyuan Market (Shanghai), Shun Kang

Market (various cities)

* Small electronics shops

* Clothing stores in non-mall settings



* Souvenir and gift shops near tourist attractions

* Car repair shops (non-chain)

Never bargain:

* Shopping malls (商场 shāngchǎng) -- Fixed prices, no negotiation

* Chain stores (优衣库, H&M, etc.) -- Standard retail

* Most restaurants -- Fixed menu prices

* Pharmacies -- Government-regulated prices

* Supermarkets -- Fixed prices

Bargaining Tips:

* Start at 30-50% of the asking price at tourist markets. The vendor expects this.

* Walk away -- the most powerful bargaining tool. If the vendor calls you back, you're close to their real price.



* Buy multiple items from the same vendor for better discounts ("打包价" dǎbāo jià --

"bundle price").

* Use a calculator or phone to show numbers -- avoids language barriers.

* Be friendly and smile -- aggressive bargaining makes everyone uncomfortable.

* "太贵了!" (tài guì le! -- "Too expensive!") is the standard opener.

* "便宜一点" (piányi yīdiǎn -- "Make it cheaper") works well as a follow-up.

Street Vendor "Hard Sell" -- What's Really Happening

In tourist areas (especially in cities like Beijing, Xi'an, Guilin), you may encounter street vendors who are very persistent -- grabbing your arm, blocking your path, or following you. This can feel aggressive, but understanding the context helps:

* Their livelihood depends on tourist sales. They have seconds to get your attention.

* In Chinese business culture, persistence is seen as dedication, not rudeness.



* "不要" (bú yào -- "Don't want") with a hand wave is the standard rejection. Repeat if needed.

* Don't make eye contact or slow down if you're not interested -- any engagement is seen as potential interest.

* If someone puts something in your hand (a bracelet, a fan), just put it down and walk away. You have no obligation to buy.

The "Tea Scam" and Tourist Traps

Be aware of a common scam in tourist areas: friendly "students" invite you to a "traditional tea ceremony" or "art exhibition," then present a bill for hundreds or thousands of yuan. Other common scams:

* Tea ceremony scam -- "Let me show you a traditional tea house!" → ¥500+ bill

* Art student scam -- "Come see my school's exhibition!" → Pressure to buy paintings



* Photo scam -- Someone in costume takes a photo with you, then demands ¥50-100

Rule of thumb:

If a stranger approaches YOU in a tourist area with an unsolicited invitation, politely decline.

Where to Shop for the Best Experience

* Malls

* -- Fixed prices, clean, air-conditioned. Mix of Chinese and international brands.

* Taobao/JD.com

* -- Online shopping paradise. Everything is cheaper than in stores.

* Wet markets (菜市场)

* -- For fresh produce. Bargaining expected. Authentic local experience.

* Fabric markets



* -- Get custom-tailored clothes at a fraction of Western prices. Bargaining essential.

Sources: Sources: [高德地图](https://www.amap.com) • [淘宝](https://www.taobao.com) • [The Beijinger](https://www.thebeijinger.com/blog)

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[The Beijinger](https://www.taobao.com)



Article 4

Food Culture in China: Etiquette, Dietary Restrictions, and Navigating Halal & Religious Food

Food is the centerpiece of Chinese social life. Meals are where friendships are forged, business deals are made, and families bond. But for foreigners -- especially those with dietary restrictions due to religion, allergies, or personal preference -- navigating Chinese food culture can be challenging. This guide covers dining etiquette, how to communicate dietary needs, and the surprisingly robust halal food ecosystem in China.

Chinese Dining Etiquette: The Essentials

Dining in China follows unwritten rules that foreigners are not expected to know but will earn huge respect for following:

* Chopstick rules:



* Never stick chopsticks upright in rice (resembles incense for the dead). Don't point with chopsticks. Don't tap your bowl with them (associated with beggars).

* Tea pouring etiquette:

* When someone pours you tea, tap two fingers on the table as a "thank you" (叩指礼 kòuzhǐ lǐ). This comes from an old legend about an emperor who poured tea for his servant.

* Seating:

* The guest of honor sits facing the door. The host sits with their back to the door. Don't sit in the wrong seat -- wait for the host to direct you.

* Lazy Susan:

* At round tables, dishes rotate counterclockwise. Take food from the dish closest to you. Don't reach across the table.

* Drinking culture:



* At business meals, the host may toast (敬酒 jìngjiǔ) multiple times. "干杯" (gānbēi --

"dry glass") means drain your glass. You can substitute tea or juice -- just say

"我以茶代酒" (wǒ yǐ chá dài jiǔ -- "I'll use tea instead of alcohol").

* Fish etiquette:

* At formal dinners, the fish head points toward the guest of honor. Don't flip the fish

over (superstition: flipping = capsizing a boat, bad luck for fishermen).

* Paying the bill:

* In China, the inviter always pays. "Going Dutch" (AA制 zhì) is becoming more common

among young friends but is still rare in formal contexts. Fighting over the bill is a cultural

ritual -- offer once, then let the host pay.

Communicating Dietary Restrictions

The biggest challenge for foreigners with dietary needs is communication. Here are

essential phrases:



* Vegetarian:

* 我吃素 (wǒ chī sù) -- "I eat vegetarian." Note: Chinese vegetarian (素食 sùshí) may still include eggs and dairy. For strict vegan: 我吃纯素 (chún sù).

* No pork:

* 我不吃猪肉 (wǒ bù chī zhūròu) -- Critical for Muslim, Jewish, and Hindu visitors.

* No alcohol:

* 我不喝酒 (wǒ bù hē jiǔ).

* Allergies:

* 我对____过敏 (wǒ duì____guòmǐn) -- "I'm allergic to ____." Learn the specific allergen in Chinese.

* Halal:

* 这是清真的吗? (zhè shì qīngzhēn de ma?) -- "Is this halal?"

! Important Warning for Religious Dietary Needs



Many international students from Muslim, Jewish, Hindu, or other religious backgrounds arrive in China unsure about what they can eat. Here's what you need to know:

Halal (清真 qīngzhēn) Food in China -- A Complete Ecosystem

China has approximately 20-25 million Muslims (Hui, Uyghur, Kazakh, and other ethnic groups), and the halal food infrastructure is extensive -- far more than most foreigners expect:

- * 清真餐厅 (qīngzhēn cāntīng)

- * -- Halal restaurants are found in EVERY Chinese city, not just in the northwest. Look for the green "清真" sign, often with Arabic script.

- * What's halal:

- * All beef, lamb, chicken, and fish dishes at certified halal restaurants. These restaurants never use pork or pork-derived products (lard, etc.).

- * Hui Muslim restaurants



* -- The most common type of halal restaurant in China. Hui (回族) people are ethnically Chinese Muslims. Their food is essentially Chinese cuisine made halal -- beef noodle soup (牛肉面), lamb skewers (羊肉串), hand-pulled noodles (拉面). The food is delicious and widely loved by non-Muslims too.

* Uyghur restaurants

* -- Serve Central Asian-influenced cuisine: big plate chicken (大盘鸡), polo (抓饭 pilaf), naan bread (馕), and lamb kebabs. Common in all major cities.

* How to find halal restaurants:

* Search "清真餐厅" on Dianping (大众点评), Meituan (美团), or Amap (高德地图). You'll find dozens in any city.

What Foreign Muslims Need to Know:

* Halal food is widely available in China. You will NOT starve.

* Many university campuses have halal canteens (清真食堂) specifically for Muslim



students.

* Convenience store snacks are generally safe (packaged foods with ingredient lists).

Avoid anything with 猪肉 (pork), 猪油 (lard), or 明胶 (gelatin, which may be pork-derived).

* !

* Chinese "清真" may differ from your country's halal standards.

* Some Hui restaurants follow a more relaxed interpretation. If you require strictly certified halal, look for restaurants with Arabic signage and ask about their certification.

* !

* Hot pot (火锅) caution:

* Even at non-pork restaurants, hot pot broth may contain pork bones. Always ask:

汤底是清真的吗? (tāngdǐ shì qīngzhēn de ma? -- "Is the broth halal?")

* !

* Street food:



* Lamb skewers (羊肉串) from Uyghur vendors are almost always halal. Other street food may be cooked in the same oil as pork products.

Other Religious Dietary Notes:

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* Kosher:

* Extremely limited in China. No kosher certification system exists nationally. Some Jewish communities in Beijing and Shanghai organize kosher food through import. Best option: cook at home or eat vegetarian at halal restaurants.

* Hindu vegetarian:

* Chinese vegetarian restaurants (素食餐厅) are Buddhist-influenced and may use garlic and onion (which strict Hindu vegetarians avoid). Specify: 不要蒜不要葱 (bú yào suàn, bú yào cōng -- "No garlic, no onion").

* Buddhist vegetarian:



* Excellent availability. 素食餐厅 (sùshí cāntīng) are found near temples and in most cities. Fully plant-based, often using mock meats (素鸡, 素鸭). Some even mimic seafood textures.

Common Misconceptions About Chinese Food

* "All Chinese food is spicy" -- Only Sichuan and Hunan cuisine are spicy. Cantonese, Jiangsu, and Fujian food are mild.

* "Chinese people eat dogs everywhere" -- Dog meat consumption is extremely rare, declining rapidly, and illegal in many cities. You will never encounter it unless you specifically seek it out.

* "You can't find Western food" -- Every major city has McDonald's, KFC, Pizza Hut, Starbucks, and many independent Western restaurants.

* "Street food is unsafe" -- China's food safety has improved dramatically. Street food at busy stalls is generally safe (high turnover = fresh ingredients). Look for queues --



locals know which stalls are good.

Essential Food Phrases:

* 菜单 (càidān) -- Menu

* 买单 (mǎidān) -- "Check, please"

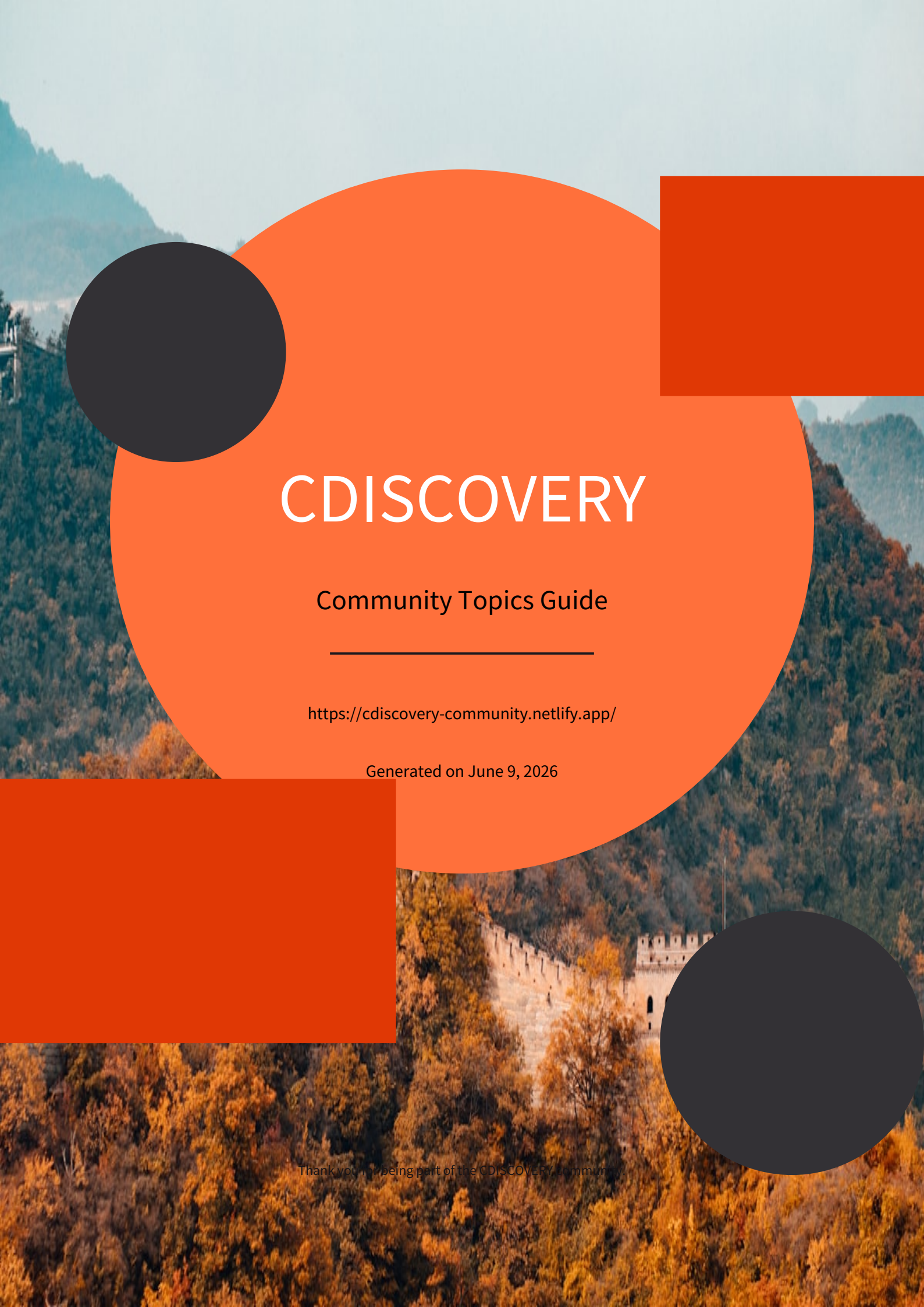
* 打包 (dǎbāo) -- "To-go box, please"

* 不要辣 (bú yào là) -- "Not spicy"

* 少盐 (shǎo yán) -- "Less salt"

* 好吃 (hǎochī) -- "Delicious" (the most useful Chinese food word!)

Sources: Sources: [国家宗教事务局](http://www.saraa.gov.cn) • [大众点评](https://www.dianping.com) • [China Daily Food & Culture](http://www.chinadaily.com.cn)



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